Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John Donne's Meditation XVII

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the two extended metaphors informing John Donne's Meditation XVII include

alliteration,
analogy,
anaphora,
asyndeton,
conceit,
connotation,
controlling image,
denotation,
diction,
epiphany,
imagery,
liminality,
metaphor,
metonymy,
onomatopoeia,
personification,
polyptoton,
rhetorical question,
simile,
speaker,
symbol,
synecdoche,
tenor,
theme,
tone, and
vehicle.

The student might dwell on the bell's tolling as a symbol of death. At some level the metaphor is at work, and certainly, the auditory imagery as symbolic of death (and metonymic representation of the final threshold-crossing) is a controlling image enveloping this excerpted passage.

The contestant might include in her or his discussion the historically-developed Pauline-Lukan Body of Christ metaphor, which is, however, not *developed* in this particular Donne meditation—it is simply a culturally-understood analogy.

Within the excerpted passage, two developed metaphors stand out: the first is that each created person is a book with a common creator-author, and the second is the argument that "no man is an island." The strong analysis will recognize the shared tenors (the individual awaiting death) and the differing vehicles (the book with its one volume, its many chapters, the several translators; and the promontory with its clods).

Both metaphors speak to the unity of man and each man's responsibility for the other, this responsebility being a reinforcement of the base-line analogy, the Pauline-Lukan Body of Christ metaphor that reminds Christians that they are members, together, of a community—the church.